shrunk to barely 5-10 metres at several places. There was a Sulabh complex outside the temple, but no washrooms in the compound. "Elderly priests used obscure corners of the temple to attend to nature's call," says an official associated with the renovation work.

"The ambience of the entrance gates was anything but spiritual. Pilgrims had to walk barefoot on a stretch littered with garbage," says Puri resident Bibhu Mishra. The problems had been there for a long time, but the government seems to have woken up to them only after the BJP's rise as the principal Opposition in the state and its performance in the 2019 Lok Sabha election.

The Odisha government has opened its purse strings for at least a dozen other temples, including Samaleshwari Temple in Sambalpur, Ma Sarala Temple in Jagatsinghpur, Biraja Temple in Jajpur, Tara Tarini Temple in Ganjam, Ma Chandi Temple in Cuttack and Neela Madhaba Temple in Nayagarh. Besides, the heritage crematorium in Puri spread over 1.2 acres has been taken up for beautification for the first time at a cost of Rs 6 crore. Grand plans are also under way for widening the approach way of both the 11th-century Lingaraj Temple in Bhubaneswar and the 13th-century Sun Temple in Konark by evicting hawkers and removing unauthorised constructions.

Work for the SMPP and at Lingaraj could begin at lightning speed because of a comprehensive relief and rehabilitation (R&R) package. Those who lost dwelling units of 50 sq. m (538 sq. ft) area were given three options: a one-time assistance of Rs 30 lakh or a dwelling unit of 520 sq. ft area or a 1,000 sq. ft plot in the proposed R&R colony within 1.5-2 km from the temple complex. Displaced families opting for accommodation in the R&R colony were entitled to a transportation cost of Rs 50,000 annually and Rs 10,000 as monthly rental assistance for a year till their houses were ready. Those who lost their shops were given alternative units in prime locations close to the temple complex and got an assistance of Rs 60,000 to Rs 1.8 lakh during the transition period. Evicted street vendors got a one-time assistance of Rs 30,000.

Land acquisition began in November 2019 and the eviction exercise was completed by the time the final masterplan got the green signal from the Shree Jagannath Temple Management Authority in February 2021. People could then see the temple's boundary wall from a distance, while the facade and surroundings got a new lease of life. What surprised everyone, especially the BJP, was that there was no hue and cry over eviction, even though 600 people lost their land, houses, shops and livelihood. "Ninety-nine per cent of the land came to us through the direct purchase scheme. Only five or six cases are pending in court," says an official of the public works department.

SPEEDBREAKERS

Except for suggesting some minor cosmetic changes—shifting the reception centre and office room from the 75-metre prohibited area—the ASI has not been able to pin-point what really bothers it. It was after the National Monument Authority (NMA) gave its "no objection" on September 2021 to a shelter pavilion, cloak room and toilets within the prohibited area that everything got stonewalled at the ASI's end. Odisha government officials argue that the NMA is the final authority for the Jagannath Temple as there are no heritage by-laws, which would have required the ASI's intervention. In May 2021, on being approached by the state's director of culture, the superintendent of archaeology sent a five-member team to the site. The NMA's green signal was on the basis of the review by this team.

An affidavit submitted by the ASI to the Orissa High Court also revealed it had no major problem with the plan. "Works such as toilets, drains, electrical wires do not fall within the definition of construction...[and] can be carried out even in the prohibited area," it said. The ASI had reservations over a reception counter planned within the 75-metre-wide corridor. Even the ASI's director general, who was on an inspection in Puri and Bhubaneswar on February 21, 2022, mentioned that the "proposed amenities are required for devotees and as agreed this may be allowed".



ARABINDA MAHAPATRA

"IF NAVEEN TAKES ALL THE CREDIT FOR TEMPLE BEAUTIFICATION, THE BJP'S AGENDA TO STIR HINDU SENTIMENTS HERE WILL BECOME REDUNDANT," SAYS AN OFFICIAL